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From the editor-in-chief

One of my most favourite times every year is when I take two days out from the usual grind to be a part of the India Today Conclave. The Conclave, now in its eighth year, brings together the finest minds in the world across all fields. Politicians and economists, academicians and spiritual leaders, writers and athletes, scientists and film stars not only give us their views on their field of knowledge but interact with the audience in a very informal manner.

This year, I thought the theme of the Conclave was right on the button. In the backdrop of financial upheaval and an escalation of the threat to global security, the 2009 India Today Conclave dealt with the "Challenges of Change". The two challenges before the world today are the economic meltdown and the changing matrix of global terrorism.

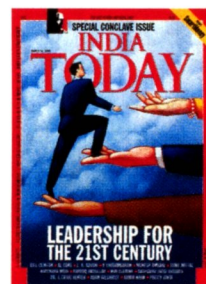
Only in such times could you have economists described as 'rockstars' and we had one of them. The Dalai Lama, who opened the Conclave, said the 21st Century should be known as the century of dialogue as opposed to the century of conflict that had preceded it. India, he said, has a major role to play in the global dialogue process. Former French prime minister Dominique De Villepin too emphasised that co-operation between countries was mandatory to tackle the sceptre of terrorism.

As always, the Conclave made news, this time even before it began. The news that General Pervez Musharraf would be a speaker at the event was greeted with bewilderment and suspicion. I was often asked, why were we giving the architect of Kargil a platform for personal propaganda? But that's the whole point of the Conclave: to get different perspectives on relevant subjects. At this moment nothing is more important than the state of Indo-Pak relations and the words of a former President, who had quit office just six months ago after 10 years of being in charge. The General, the keynote speaker at the gala dinner, did not disappoint. He came to the Conclave a seemingly changed man, talking of peace and asking for both countries to shed the burden of history. The standing-room-only audience challenged him, provoked him and for his part, Musharraf held his ground. He was charming, full of humour and all guns blazing when needed. His session was so riveting that it lasted three hours.

That wasn't all. Former chess champion and now political activist Garry Kasparov told us all was not well in the state of Russia. Economist Nouriel Roubini, who predicted the slowdown two years ago, told us in his impassive monotone that the world economy would not recover until the United States did. His forecast was that would not happen until after 2010. Bollywood superstar Shah Rukh Khan talked with great wit about wanting to be an entertainer while the audience wanted him to use his iconic status for making films with meaningful social messages.

The cover story of this special issue condenses all that happened at the Conclave. If you want to know more, the complete transcripts of the Conclave debates are available on our website www.indiatodayconclave.in. Like it did for us, I hope this feast of debate gives you a better understanding of the challenges we face today and changes the way you look at the future.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)



OUR MARCH 2008
CONCLAVE COVER